distinctive yellow chevron patterns down its back – streaking across the road ahead of our car, so long that its body extended all the way across the road, leaving us all stricken with horror. By the time the last of the four Vedas, the *Atharva-Veda*, had been composed in about 800 BCE, its authors knew all about snakes and lived in terror of them; consequently it devotes whole chapters to charms for the exorcism of black, white and striped snakes from dwellings. Only later did the Arya reach a true accommodation with snakes, so that by the time the domestic rituals known as the *Grihya Sutra*s had been assembled in about 400 BCE the snake was becoming akin to a god. Now householders are required to put out a special bowl in a special place, and fill it with clean water with the invocation 'Honour to the divine serpents'. The words *Naag* and *Nagas*, referring both to the cobra and to a race of quasi-divine half-man, half-snake beings of the underworld, have also started to appear in sacred texts and mythology.

The first of the two great Indian epics, the *Mahabharata*, is filled with stories of snakes both as quasi-gods and as people, usually presented as hostiles who are converted to become protectors and allies of humanity. The most disturbing of these tales is the *Mahabharata*'s account of a pogrom which almost brings about the extermination of the snake race. This starts with the burning of the ancient forest of Khandava, west of the Jumna (Yamuna) River in what is now the Delhi region, which is the abode of 'the enemies of the gods', who are Nagas led by the snake-king Takshaka. The snake-hating Arya king Janamejaya drives the snake-people out of the forest by fire and executes their leaders in a *sarpa satra* or snake sacrifice. A boy sage named Astika, who is the offspring of a Brahmin father and a Naga mother, then calls on Janamejaya to stop the killing and to set Takshaka free – and from this time onwards the Nagas and the Arya live together in peace.